

Hamish the Highland Cow

US terms - Intermediate - 6-8 hours

A shaggy, sturdy Highland cow with a flattened brow, a wide cream muzzle and a weather-beaten fringe. Worked in pieces so every proportion can be pinned and checked before sewing.

FINISHED SIZE About 15 cm (6 in) sitting in worsted weight, with a 70 mm wide body and a 70 x 67 mm head. Low, sprawling Highland sit.

Safety - read this first

Hamish has two 12 mm safety eyes - small parts. Lock the washers firmly from the inside and pull-test each eye. The horns, ears, muzzle, legs and tail are sewn on, and the fringe and tail are knotted yarn: sew every seam twice, weave ends in at least 5 cm, and knot the fringe and tail securely.

Important eye-order correction: insert the eyes between Rnds 9 and 10 but do not attach the washers until the muzzle has been pinned and the face placement checked. Lock the washers while the head opening is still accessible, before fully closing the head.

Not tested to ASTM F963 or EN 71 - do not describe finished Hamishes as "baby-safe". For children under three, embroider the eyes with black floss instead of safety eyes.

Materials

- **Yarn A - Ginger:** Worsted / aran (#4), about 25 g used. Caramel, toffee or ginger gold. One 80 g / 150 m ball covers several cows and re-dos.
- **Yarn B - Oat cream:** Worsted / aran (#4), about 12 g. Muzzle, horns, inner ears, optional belly patch.
- **Yarn C - Dark chocolate:** Worsted / aran (#4), about 5 g. Hooves and nostrils.
- **Yarn D - Rust (optional):** About 6 g for the scarf, or 28 cm of 12 mm tartan ribbon.
- **Hook:** 3.5 mm (US E-4) - smaller than the ball band so stuffing cannot show.
- **Eyes:** 2 x 12 mm black safety eyes, or embroider for under-threes.
- **Stuffing & notions:** Polyester fibre fill about 30 g (buy 50 g to over-stuff the base); stitch marker, tapestry needle, pins, scissors.

Gauge & size

Gauge: 11 sc x 12 rounds = 5 cm / 2 in in Yarn A. Not critical, but loose tension lets stuffing show - drop half a millimetre if your fabric is gappy. Finished size about 15 cm / 6 in sitting.

Abbreviations

- **MR** magic ring
- **ch** chain

- **sl st** slip stitch
- **sc** single crochet
- **hdc** half double crochet
- **inc** 2 sc in one stitch
- **dec** invisible decrease
- **BLO** back loop only
- **FO** fasten off
- **(n)** stitch count at round/row end

Work in a continuous spiral unless a round says join. Mark the first stitch of every round. Leave 30-40 cm tails on every piece you will sew.

Techniques

1. **The magic ring:** Wrap yarn around two fingers, insert the hook, pull up a loop and work the first round into the ring; pull the tail tight once the round is complete.
2. **Work in a spiral:** Do not join and do not chain 1 between rounds. Move the marker up each time - there is no join to count from.
3. **Invisible decrease:** Insert the hook through the front loops only of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two. Every dec is worked this way - no ridge on visible rounds.
4. **Back loop only (BLO):** Work into the far loop only, leaving the near loop unused; the unused loops form a raised ridge. Hamish's hoof line is one BLO round.
5. **Working around a chain:** For the belly patch, crochet into both sides of a starting chain: across the front, corner increases into the last chain, then back along the opposite side - turning a chain into a flat oval.
6. **The lark's head knot:** Fold a strand in half, push the folded loop under a stitch with the hook, pull the two loose ends through the loop and cinch. Used for every fringe strand and the tail.
7. **Ladder stitch:** The invisible seam: out on one side, pick up one bar on the opposite side, then one bar back, alternating, pulling snug every few stitches. The head-to-body join needs two full passes.

1. Head - Yarn A

Worked from the crown down toward the neck. One straight round only - that is what keeps the brow flat and wide instead of egg-shaped. Close to 6 stitches at the end.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	6	
R2	inc in each st around	12	
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	30	
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	36	fringe row 3
R7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	42	fringe row 2 / horn bases
R8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	48	fringe row 1 / ears
R9	sc in each st around	48	eyes between R9 and R10
R10	[6 sc, dec] x 6	42	
R11	[5 sc, dec] x 6	36	

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R12	[4 sc, dec] x 6	30	stuff firmly, flatten front to back
R13	[3 sc, dec] x 6	24	
R14	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	
R15	[sc, dec] x 6	12	last pinch of stuffing
R16	dec x 6	6	close the hole after washers are locked

Eyes & head size

Place the 12 mm eyes between Rnds 9 and 10, 7 stitches apart and a touch low on the face (7 sts ~ 32 mm, just under half the head width). Do not lock the washers until the muzzle is pinned and the face placement is confirmed. Finished head ~ 70 mm wide x 67 mm tall.

Corrected eye and muzzle order: work the head through R15, leaving the opening accessible. Insert the safety eyes without washers. Pin the muzzle in place just under the eyes and check the expression. When you are happy with the face, attach and pull-test the washers from inside the head. Finish stuffing, work R16, close the hole, then sew the muzzle fully in place.

2. Muzzle - Yarn B

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	6	
R2	inc in each st around	12	
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
R5	sc in each st around	24	face at full width, 35 mm
R6	sc in each st around	24	
R7	sc in each st around	24	
R8	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	rim = 26 mm across

Finish: FO with a 40 cm tail and stuff lightly. The muzzle face is about 35 mm across (the wide cream patch you see); the rim it sews by is about 26 mm, spanning roughly six rounds of head. Pin the top edge just under the eyes at Rnd 10 and let the lower edge fall at Rnd 15-16 near the chin. Centre it, let the face sit a little wider than the eye spacing, and sew with small whip stitches, adding a whisper more stuffing before you close.

Nostrils (Yarn C): two short vertical satin stitches, 3 stitches apart, on the lower third. Mouth: one tiny horizontal stitch or a shallow V below them. The wide cream muzzle, low-set eyes and shaggy fringe give the Highland stare.

3. Body - Yarn A

Worked bottom up. The neck is left open at 18 stitches for the head join.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	6	
R2	inc in each st around	12	
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	30	

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	36	
R7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	42	
R8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	48	front legs join R8-R9
R9	sc in each st around	48	
R10	sc in each st around	48	body at full width, 70 mm
R11	sc in each st around	48	
R12	sc in each st around	48	
R13	sc in each st around	48	
R14	[6 sc, dec] x 6	42	
R15	sc in each st around	42	
R16	[5 sc, dec] x 6	36	
R17	[4 sc, dec] x 6	30	stuff firmly, pack the base
R18	[3 sc, dec] x 6	24	
R19	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	leave neck open

Finish: FO with a 40 cm tail; do not close. Body is ~19 rounds (79 mm); with the head seated on the neck ring the finished sitting height is about 15 cm / 6 in.

4. Belly patch - Yarn B, optional

A flat oval worked around a chain.

Ch 9.

- R1: sc in 2nd ch from hook, sc in next 6, 3 sc in last ch, sc in next 6, 2 sc in last loop (18)
- R2: inc, 6 sc, inc x 3, 6 sc, inc x 2 (24)
- R3: sc, inc, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x 3, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x 2 (30)
- R4: 2 sc, inc, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x 3, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x 2 (36)

Sl st, FO, long tail; sew centred on the front with the lower edge about 3 rounds up from the base. Skip it for a plain ginger front - both are correct.

5. Legs - Yarn C then Yarn A, make 4

For the standard low Highland sit, make all four legs to Rnd 16. The sitting pose comes from where and at what angle you sew them. Sixteen rounds = a 67 mm leg.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR (Yarn C)	6	hoof
R2	inc in each st around	12	
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
R4	sc in each st around	18	
R5	sc in each st around	18	
R6	BLO sc around	18	change to Yarn A - ridge
R7	sc in each st around	18	

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R8	[sc, dec] x 6	12	stuff hoof firmly
R9	sc in each st around	12	
R10	sc in each st around	12	
R11	sc in each st around	12	
R12	sc in each st around	12	
R13	sc in each st around	12	upper leg light
R14	[2 sc, dec] x 3	9	
R15	sc in each st around	9	
R16	sc in each st around	9	leave top open

Leg length - read before you sew

A 67 mm leg joins much lower than it is long, so it splays: front ~55 degrees from vertical, back ~68-70 degrees (near horizontal) - that is the low Highland sit.

Variation: for a tidier upright sit, make the front pair only through Rnd 10 (42 mm) and make the back pair through Rnd 16 as haunches.

6. Ears - make 2 inner and 2 outer

Inner ear - Yarn B, make 2

- R1: 6 sc in MR (6)
- R2: [sc, inc] x 3 (9)
- R3: [2 sc, inc] x 3 (12)

FO.

Outer ear - Yarn A, make 2

- R1: 6 sc in MR (6)
- R2: [sc, inc] x 3 (9)
- R3: [2 sc, inc] x 3 (12)

Place the inner ear on the outer ear, cream facing you, before working the outer ear's Rnd 4.

- R4: sc around through both layers (12)
- R5: sc around (12)
- R6: [2 sc, dec] x 3 (9)
- R7: sc around (9)

Flatten, FO, and pinch the base with 2-3 stitches so the ear cups forward.

7. Horns - Yarn B, make 2

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	4 sc in MR	4	
R2	[sc, inc] x 2	6	
R3	sc in each st around	6	
R4	sc in each st around	6	
R5	[2 sc, inc] x 2	8	
R6	sc in each st around	8	
R7	sc in each st around	8	stuff tip only

FO with a tail; stuff the tip only. Short and slightly curved - tilt each horn out and a little back when you sew. Sew horns with their bases spanning Rnds 5-7, centred near Rnd 7, 6 stitches apart.

8. Tail - Yarn A

Cut 6 strands of Yarn A, each 22 cm / 8.5 in. Fold the bundle in half and attach with a lark's head at the centre-back just above the last increase round: pull the folded loop through a stitch, then the tails through the loop. Folding gives 12 hanging ends; divide into 3 groups of 4, braid 4 cm, knot firmly and trim into a small tassel.

9. The fringe - Yarn A

Attach after the horns and ears so you can part the hair around them. Cut 44 strands, each 14 cm / 5.5 in, including one spare strand. Swap up to 6 strands for Yarn C for depth.

Attach with lark's head knots in a horseshoe from one ear, across the brow, to the other, filling three front rows: about 24 knots across the front/brow section of Rnd 8, then about 10 knots on Rnd 7 and 9 knots on Rnd 6. This uses about 43 knots total. Tousle, then trim so the fringe grazes the eyes and breaks into uneven points. Highland hair is weather-beaten, not a salon fringe.

10. Optional tartan scarf - Yarn D

Ch 61.

- Row 1: hdc in 2nd ch from hook and across (60)
- Row 2: ch 1, turn, hdc across (60)

FO; add a 3-strand tassel at each end or weave a second colour as a slip-stitch stripe to hint at tartan, then tie loosely under the muzzle.

Ribbon shortcut: 28 cm of 12 mm rust tartan ribbon, knotted once.

Assembly checklist

1. Muzzle and face pinned; safety-eye washers locked while the head opening is still accessible.
2. Horns between Rnds 5 and 7, 6 stitches apart, angled out and slightly back.
3. Ears just outside and below each horn, centred on Rnds 8-9, cupped forward.
4. Fringe attached and trimmed, parting around horns and ears.

5. Head to body: closed head on the open 18-st neck ring (body Rnd 19). Ball-on-ring join - pack the neck firmly, ladder-stitch around twice, tilt the muzzle slightly down.
6. Back legs: lower sides across Rnds 3-6, almost on the base, splayed near horizontal.
7. Front legs: front across Rnds 8-9, about 8 sts apart, angled forward ~55 degrees.
8. Belly patch only if you made it.
9. Tail and scarf: attach the tassel tail, tie the scarf, weave in every end and fluff the fringe.

Three sizes, one pattern

Version	Yarn / Hook	Eyes	Height
Wee Hamish	DK / #3 - 2.75 mm	8-9 mm	~12 cm
Classic Worsted	Worsted / #4 - 3.5 mm	12 mm	~15 cm
Cuddle Hamish	Bulky chenille / #5 - 5.0 mm	16-18 mm	~21 cm

Stitch counts stay the same; only yarn, hook and stuffing change. Yarn scales with the square of the height and stuffing with the cube - buy generously for the big chenille version.

Troubleshooting

- **He will not sit.** Restuff the body base firmly and sew the back legs lower and wider - closer to horizontal than you think.
- **Front hooves float.** Sewn too high - they belong on Rnds 8-9, not under the neck. If they still float, the legs are too long: work the front pair to Rnd 10.
- **Stuffing shows.** Drop half a hook size, or hold a matching thread with the yarn on visible rounds.
- **Face looks blank.** The eyes are too high. Low eyes plus a wide muzzle is the Highland stare.
- **Fringe is sparse.** Add a fourth row behind the horns and mix in one darker shade.
- **Horns flop.** Under-stuffed at the tip, or sewn only at the edge - stitch a full round into the head fabric.
- **Head tips forward.** The neck ring grips the head only about 8 mm up. Pack the neck before closing and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight.

Colorways

Ginger - Caramel Highland - Black - Cream Roan - Red

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Safety reminder

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard (ASTM F963 / EN 71) and uses 12 mm safety eyes and knotted yarn fringe. Finished items made for sale must be assessed by the seller against local toy-safety laws; for young children, embroider the eyes and secure every seam and knot.

Happy crocheting!

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